



Labor is a process, a series of changes that will finally bring your baby into your arms. Although clinically there are signs, phases, and markers, **each woman's labor is different** from another's. If this is your second or subsequent baby, the experience will be unlike your previous ones—it's **unique and remarkable**.

Being in labor

Understanding the big event

Your doctor and doctors will refer to labor as having three stages. The first stage is usually the longest, beginning with the first contractions and sometimes a “bloody show” (see p.206) that indicates that your cervix has started to open, and lasting until your cervix is fully dilated. The second stage is characterized by the act of pushing your baby down the birth canal and out into the world. The third stage refers to the delivery of the placenta and membranes. It's always helpful to be aware of the terms your doctor will use, but in practice labor is really just a single event that begins with a few small signs and ends with the emergence of your baby.

Listen to your body

Referring to labor in clinical terms—stages, centimeters, and time spans—while helpful for a medical staff, isn't really what labor is about for you. This is a magical time: the start or expanding of a family, the beginning of new life, and a time when your body performs the most

natural, fundamental, and significant event. Many women worry about labor—how they will “deal” with it, will they be “good” at it, will labor follow the clinical patterns they have read so much about? It's helpful to remember that clinical markers are not “rules” and there isn't one set way to give birth—try not to focus on what stage you're in, whether you are 2cm or 9cm dilated, or how many hours your baby has shown signs of coming. Instead, concentrate on listening to your body, responding to its signals (don't worry—they will be obvious), and focusing on the baby that you will soon be able to hold. Remain as calm as you can and stay warm. Stress inhibits the release of oxytocin, which is the hormone that triggers your contractions. Walk around if it makes you feel more at ease, or sit or stand, or lean over an exercise ball. There is no rule that says you must lie in a bed.

If you need to be hooked up to a monitor for medical reasons, you can still stand or sit on a chair or ball and let gravity lend you a helping hand. Make this an event that feels right for you.